IS5116: Digital Entrepreneurship

Semester I 2026-2027

Team Startup Project

School of Computing
National University of Singapore

Final Team Startup Project

- Team members will assume the roles of founders of a start-up company: CEO, CTO, finance, marketing etc.
- Each team will develop a new tech start-up venture
- Each team will produce a business proposal & slide deck on the new venture and present to the class
  - A 90-second min elevator pitch
  - A 5-minute investment pitch to raise seed funding
- Teams will be graded on
  - the business proposal
  - the investment deck
  - the elevator pitch
  - the investment pitch

Final Team Project Grading

- The Final Team project will make up 50% of total course grade
- Grading will be based on
  - Quality of Investment Proposal (20%)
  - Effectiveness of presentation & quality of slides (20%)
  - Effectiveness of elevator pitch (10%)
- The written submission **must not exceed 25 pages**; annexes should not exceed 10 pages
- Slide deck to be **no more than 16**, excluding backup slides
- All material are to be submitted to Assignment 'Final Project' on Canvas
- Document names should be 'Team X Business Proposal' (Word/PDF) and 'Team X Deck' (PPT/PDF).
- Peer reviews will be taken into account in grading

Admin Arrangements

- All elevator pitches will be presented first
- Investment pitches will be presented in the same order
- The class will play the role of investors – asking questions at the end of each presentation
- You will each rank the elevator pitches and investment pitches separately from 1 (best) to 12 (worst) using the survey tool on Canvas
- You will rank your own team as 0.
- The aggregate class score will constitute 50% of the marks for presentations

Setting for Elevator Pitch

- You struck up conversation with a prospective investor at a networking event and mentioned that you have a great idea that he might be interested in.
- He says to you, “OK, I’ve got a couple of minutes to hear you out. Tell me why I should be interested in your idea?”
- Your pitch should be spontaneous and natural, like in a normal conversation so you should not be using slides or reading from notes or cue cards
- You should give a complete pitch within 90 seconds
- Your objective is to secure a separate appointment to make a proper pitch for investment

Elevator Pitch Examples

- Travel Blender (2011) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=r_Dgsf4iiZg&list=PLCD38F0B92AA98290&index=3
- Mark 3 ID (2012) https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=BIo-enMAIxE&list=PLCD38F0B92AA98290&index=8
- Solanux: Healthier potato products https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=3aXIMNZJ2xQ

Rules for Elevator Pitch

- You have 90 seconds for the pitch
- You cannot use any handouts or slides
- A bell will sound at the end of 60 secs; you should prepare to wrap up your pitch in the remaining 30 secs

Setting for Investment Pitch

- Your startup has been selected to pitch to a group of potential investors
- You have at most 5 minutes to do your presentation and attract the investors' interest
- Your main objective is to convince the investors to take your idea seriously so he would follow up with you as an investment prospect
- You are free to use the time allotted however you wish, to achieve this objective.

Pitch Deck Guide

- For a 5-minute pitch, you will probably use about a dozen slides
- The templates shown give an idea of the presentation flow and the information to be shared
- Apply common sense to the design of your slides: they should help you put across the points you wish to communicate effectively
- Remember, communication happens at the receiver, not at the transmitter

Content of Pitch Deck

1. Cover
2. Problem/Opportunity: the big pain or big value
3. Value proposition: how are you solving the pain?
4. Customer: who are you serving?
5. Market size; target market
6. Product: How does it work?
7. Competition
8. Positioning
9. Business model
10. Team
11. Financials
12. Why us?

Sequoia Capital Pitch Deck Template

1. Company Purpose
2. Problem
3. Solution
4. Why Now
5. Market Size
6. Competition
7. Product
8. Business Model
9. Team Financials

Demo Day Pitches

Y Combinator's Demo Day

- Vastrm – Custom fit clothes (2012)
  - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bOWVcvaxzOk
- Asseta – Used capital equipment marketplace (2013)
  - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AGEdHAT_f-k&list=PLSId5Ee-5md-kg0Nkl4Ov6BoBubSvIfh2
- Lollipuff – Designer goods resale market (2013)
  - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6gtl01RuSVU
- Goodybag - Food ordering for the Enterprise (2016)
  - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ScDKs8m3CdU
- Doordash – Food delivery (2013)
  - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YNAOXokK--o

Singapore Pitches

Entrepreneur First Singapore 2017/2018

- Hydroleap: Industrial Waste Water Treatment
  - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=t-73OX-T8Wk
- MediosTechnologies: AI for detecting diabetic retinopathy
  - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=VB4M4O12zjM

Rules for Investment Pitch

- You have up to 5 minutes for your pitch
- A bell will sound at the end of 4 minutes; you should wrap up your pitch within the next minute

Judging Criteria for Elevator Pitch

- Did the presenter communicate his message well?
  - Clearly, coherently and confidently?
  - With energy and enthusiasm?
- Did the key points get through?
  - The customer and market
  - A sound value proposition
- If you were an investor, would you be drawn by the pitch to find out more about the investment opportunity?

Judging Criteria for Investor Pitch

- Quality of Presentation (50%)
  - Did the presenter speak clearly and logically?
  - Was there energy and enthusiasm in the presentation?
  - Were the market definition, value proposition and competitive advantage put across well?
- Quality of Content (50%)
  - Were the slides well designed?
  - Was the presentation complete?
  - Did you, as the potential investor, have enough information to decide whether you want to proceed further?

Team Business Proposal Format

1. Executive summary
2. Problem statement and value proposition
3. Market identification and analysis
4. Company products and services
5. Competitive marketing & sales strategy
6. Sustainable competitive advantage
7. Team
8. Operational plan
9. Expansion plan
10. Financials
11. Conclusion

Adapted from Expara ‘s
Business Plan Outline 2008

Business Proposal Guide

- The proposal format covers the important information that investors look for
- You need not follow this to the letter, you can combine sections or re-order the flow if you think it suits your business idea better
- The questions for each section are meant to help you address the important parts of the business; not all may apply, address those that are relevant
- Keep at a consistent level of detail for the sections except for the executive summary and conclusion

1 Executive summary

- 1-2 page summary of key points of the business
- It should bring out clearly the business opportunity, market positioning and value proposition in a way that will be attractive to investors
- It should indicate the amount of funding to be raised and the expected exit and ROI for investors

The executive summary is not the introduction – it is a condensed version of the business plan! This may be all the investor will ever read!

2 Problem statement and value proposition

- What is the big pain you are solving for customers? Or the big value you're giving them?
- What is your product or service offering and what is innovative about it?
- What are the shortfalls of current solutions?
- Can you quantify the benefits of your solution?

3 Market identification and analysis

- How big is your market and how fast is it growing?
- Who is your primary customer? Your secondary customers?
- How is your market segmented? What segment(s) are your targeting; what is the size of this segment and what share can you aim for?
- What trends in your market are favourable for you?
  - technological, social, demographic, regulatory

4 Company products and services

- Describe the products or services you are selling
- Illustrate with figures and diagrams where possible

5 Competitive marketing & sales strategy

- Who are your direct and indirect customers?
- Where do you compete in the market? Use a positioning map to illustrate
- How is your product differentiated from your competitors? Use a comparison matrix to illustrate why yours is better
- Do you have a tagline for your product?
- What is your sales strategy in terms of price, promotion and market entry

6 Sustainable competitive advantage

- How will you compete with followers or clones?
- How will you compete with large companies who decide to move into your space?
- What is your IP strategy?
- What are your competitive strategies to create barriers to entry?
- What are the critical success factors of the business? Do you have them?

7 Team

- Who are the core team members? What are their backgrounds, competencies and experience?
- What does each member bring to the company?
- Do you have all the competencies you need for the company in your team?

8 Operational plan

- Put up the business model canvas or the lean canvas of the company
- How do you execute the business plan?
- What are the key activities, timeline and milestones?
- What resources are needed to execute well?
- What are the risks and what is your mitigation strategy?

* don’t talk about common sense stuff that is common to all companies; be specific to your business and industry

9 Expansion plan

- How will the activities scale up?
- What is the timeline of expansion?
- What resources are needed for expansion?
- What are the risks and what is your mitigation strategy?

* don’t talk about common sense stuff that is common to all companies; be specific to your business and industry

10 Financials

- What is the business model ie. how does the business make money?
- What are the key sources of revenue and the main cost items?
- Give a high-level summary of the financials
  - 5-year projection of P&L
  - 18-month quarterly cashflow projection
- What investment is required and for what equity?
- How will the proceeds be used?
- What is the exit strategy and the expected ROI for investors?

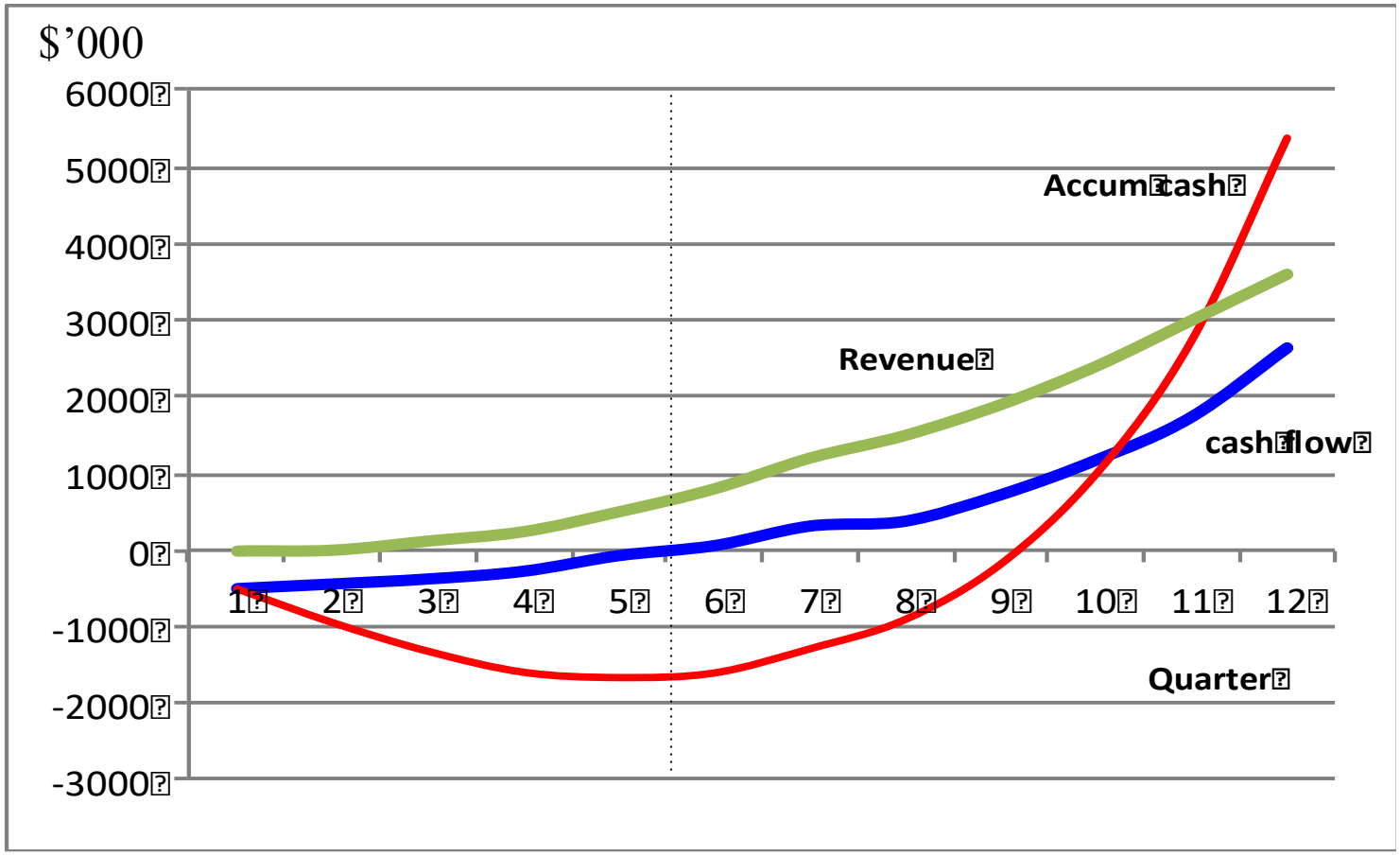
11 Conclusion

- Summarise the key points of interest to investors
  - Market opportunity
  - Value proposition and Innovation
  - Team
- Call to Action
  - Investment required and expected ROI

Appendices

- **Supporting material**
  - Resumes of core team (highlight relevance to business)
  - Patent information (if any)
  - Market research findings: market size & projections
  - Detailed financials:
    - 5-year P&L
    - Monthly or quarterly cashflow for 18 months
  - Customer testimonials and endorsements (if available)

Quarter Cashflow of ABC Startup Pte Ltd



Quarter	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
Revenue	0	0	120	240	500	800	1200	1500	1900	2400	3000	3600
Cash flow	-500	-440	-375	-275	-70	60	315	380	725	1175	1740	2640
Accum Cash	-500	-940	-1315	-1590	-1660	-1600	-1285	-905	-180	995	2735	5375

Business Proposal Tips

- Work on something as real as you can
- Think about problems encountered at work; complaints from friends & colleagues; possible products that could improve convenience and satisfaction; combinations of features of existing products that will make them even more useful
- Go niche – don't try to be everything to everybody
- Try to tear down your ideas and challenge your assumptions as you plan – it is better for you to pick out your own shortcomings and address them rather than have others pick them out for you
- Prepare a list of questions that investors will ask and make sure you have good answers
- Have specific strategies and plans, not 'motherhood' statements

Advice for Writing the Business Proposal

- Avoid long stretches of text. Use charts, tables, diagrams to present ideas and concepts; have comfortable size fonts, spacing etc. Make the report easy to read.
- The VC is a business savvy and tech savvy person. Don't pad your report with general business or technology concepts that he knows eg. describing the role of CEO, CTO etc.
- Concentrate on the important stuff that VCs look for:
  - Market: is it sizeable and growing?
  - Product: is there strong product-market fit? Does it address a big pain?
  - Team: can the founding team deliver?
  - Why now?

Questions Every Investor Will Ask

- Can the team adequately describe their ideas?
- Is there a strong value proposition?
- What is the quality of the entrepreneurs?
- Do they understand their business? Do they know the critical factors such as cost per item, break even, sales per product?
- Do they understand the market? Who will buy? Why?
- Do they understand the competition? Who are the key competitors? What are their market share?
- Did they take into account all the known risks?
- Is the action plan realistic and executable?

Attributes of a Good Business Plan

- Clear market definition
- Clear and strong value proposition
- Good understanding of the business space
- Knows the target customer well
- Understands the competition and knows how to be different and better
- Sound business model that can scale
- Takes into account all significant risks
- Action plan is realistic and executable